

family of 14 children, only five of whom survived beyond infancy. His father was a schoolmaster and a cellist (though a poor one); music was often played in the household, and Franz's outstanding talent was soon noticed. In 1808, he won a scholarship to sing in the Austrian Imperial Court Chapel choir, which carried with it the right to be educated as a boarder at the prestigious Royal Seminary school.

A society figure

Schubert's elite education brought him into contact with pupils from a higher social class, some of whom would remain his friends throughout his life. He took lessons in composition from the court composer Antonio Salieri (1750–1825)—notorious for his earlier rivalry with Mozart—and composed with extraordinary facility by early adolescence. By the time he left the Seminary in 1813, Schubert had already written songs, dances, choral works, chamber music, and even his First Symphony.

Following the death of his mother, he returned home to become a reluctant assistant teacher at his father's school, but the flow of compositions continued. In the space of a single year in 1815 he wrote almost 150 songs, including a dramatic setting of Johann Wolfgang von Goethe's ballad "Erlkönig" that was to become one of his most popular works.

Schubert found an escape from teaching through his circle of friends. With the support of young aristocrats, including the wealthy literary dilettante Franz von Schober and Joseph von Spaun, a friend from the Seminary days, he was able to leave the family home and adopt an artistic bohemian lifestyle, devoted to music, café talk, and drinking—which he often did to excess. A good-natured, gregarious individual,